LAUNCH ROADMAP

Brief! - from briefmessage.net to a product

Version 3 | Brief! 2.3.0 is live | What was done, what comes next, and why the order changed

Purpose	The steps, in order, that turn Brief! from an application that is online into a product a team can sign up for and pay for at briefmessage.net.
What changed since version 2 (October 9)	**M0, M1 and M2 are done:** Sections 4 to 7 now record what was configured. **M3 is split in two**, the next release adds a closed mode, and **the validation gate moved** (Section 3). Email will be sent through Resend.
Starting point	Brief! 2.3.0, live at https://briefmessage.net, 207 of 207 tests passing. Free plans. One board, open to anyone who finds the address.
How to read it	Prices and limits were checked on the vendors' own pages on October 9 to 11, 2026, unless a line says October 6; confirm them before you act. This is not legal, tax or financial advice (Section 13).

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1. Where Things Stand

You have	You do not have yet
A live site: https://briefmessage.net, over HTTPS, with DNSSEC	A site that is ready for strangers. Anyone can register and post; there is no bot check and no moderation
A verified build: 207 of 207 tests, on H2 and on PostgreSQL 16	Email on accounts: no password reset, no verification, no billing contact
A deployment that is described in one file (render.yaml) and repeats itself on every push	Plans that last: the free database expires on November 10 and has no backups; the free service sleeps
A pipeline: five CI jobs on every push, among them the Docker image	A rule that a failed CI run stops the deploy. Today Render deploys every commit
Addresses at your domain: hello@ and support@ arrive in your inbox	A way to send mail from the domain
A web app that installs on a phone or computer and opens without a connection	Notifications that reach the app while it is closed
One board	Private boards. Today everyone who registers sees everything
An architecture diagram and six status reports	Terms of service, privacy policy, pricing page, payment

Three rows moved from right to left since version 2: a deployment, HTTPS, and a tested build. The first row on the right is new, and it is the reason for the order of what follows.

2. What Is Being Sold

Decided on October 8: Brief! is a private board for small teams (direction B of version 1). A team of 3 to 30 gets one place for short updates that must be read. The 255-character limit is the feature; mentions are the reason to open it; the money is a small monthly subscription per board; a private group moderates itself.

> **Positioning (a hypothesis to test, not a fact)**
>
> **One sentence to test on real people:** "Brief! is a private board for your team where every post is 255 characters or less, so the things everyone must read do not drown in chat. It installs on your phone straight from the browser."
>
> It does not replace Slack or Teams. It sits beside them, as the place for the few messages a day that must not be missed.

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Adding "it works as an app on your phone"

Yes, add it. It is true as of 2.3.0 and it answers a question every team will ask. Say what it does, in words a listener can check:

Say this	Because, as of 2.3.0
"Installs on your phone from the browser. No app store."	Android, iPhone, iPad, Windows and Mac can add it to the home screen or desktop, where it opens in its own window.
"Opens instantly, even with no signal."	The app's own files are kept on the device. Posts still need a connection.
"Shows how many mentions are waiting."	On the tab title everywhere; on the app icon where the system supports it.
Not yet: "Notifies you the moment you are mentioned."	Today that works only while Brief! is open. Notifications to a closed app arrive with M3b (Section 9).
Avoid: "more reliable and efficient"	A listener cannot check it, so it sounds like every other product. The three lines above can be shown in ten seconds.

On building in a crowded market

You wrote that Brief! will be built whether or not similar products exist, because you are part of the market too. I agree with the decision. Other products are proof that teams pay for this kind of tool, and nobody needs permission to compete.

What I would keep from version 1 is the order of work, not the doubt. The large tools have free tiers, so the first question from any team will be "why not just use what we have?", and the sentence above has to answer it. "Brief" is a common word in software, so search the trademark database before paying for a logo. And this is a third product competing for the same hours as PixelPerfect and ContentCalendar.ai.

So the test with real teams stays, in two steps (Section 3): one invited team as soon as the board can be closed, five teams once boards are private. Neither decides whether to build. They decide what to build next, with evidence in place of my guesses and yours.

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Cross-promotion between Brief! and PixelPerfect

Your idea of October 11: each product points to the other. It is sound, and costs almost nothing. The form matters more than the placement you sketched:

Question	Recommendation	Why
Where on Brief!	One line in the left column, under "API docs"	The area you marked is the feed. It is empty only until the first post, and a banner there competes with the product
Who sees it	Visitors who are not signed in	A team inside its own board should never see an advertisement. A paid tool with ads looks cheap
Wording on Brief!	"Also from OneTechly: PixelPerfect, a screenshot API for developers."	Says who it is for. Most Brief! visitors are not developers
Wording on PixelPerfect	"Also from OneTechly: Brief!, a private board for short team updates."	Not "group chat": the whole pitch is that Brief! is not chat
When	Brief! side in 2.4. PixelPerfect side: one line in its footer, in its own code	Small, and belongs with the other small changes

3. The Roadmap: Milestones, and Release 2.4

Each milestone ends in something you can check. Effort is a rough estimate for evenings beside your other work.

	Milestone	What is built or done	Done when	Status
M0	**Secure the domain**	DNSSEC, two forwarding addresses. Two-factor sign-in and auto-renew still to confirm	A message to hello@briefmessage.net reached your inbox: October 10	**DONE** Section 4
M1	**A deployable build** (2.3.0)	PostgreSQL, Flyway migrations, foreign keys, Dockerfile, render.yaml	207 of 207 on your machine, October 10; Docker image built in CI	**DONE** Section 5
M2	**Online**	GitHub, Render Blueprint, custom domain, HTTPS	https://briefmessage.net showed Brief! with its data after a redeploy: October 11	**DONE** Sections 6, 7
M3a	**Accounts with email, and a closed board** (2.4)	Email on accounts, verification link, password reset, sent through Resend. Closed mode. The fixes found during deployment	A member who forgot the password recovers it by email; a stranger without the invitation code cannot register or read	**NEXT** about 1 week below
	Pilot	*One team you invite uses the closed board, on the paid plans.*	*You know what they used, and what they asked for*	**NEXT**
M3b	**Accounts, completed** (2.5)	A bot check at sign-up, account deletion, Terms and Privacy pages, push notifications for the installed app, staying signed in for more than 12 hours	A mention reaches a closed app; an account can be deleted by its owner	**LATER** 1 to 2 weeks

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	Milestone	What is built or done	Done when	Status
M4	**Private boards** (2.6)	Workspaces: every post belongs to one. Invitations by email. Roles: owner and member. A landing page	Two teams use the same server and cannot see each other's posts	**LATER** 2 to 3 weeks
	Validation gate	*Five teams, two weeks, free.*	*Would two of five pay?*	**LATER**
M4a	**Attachments** (2.7)	Images, PDF and text files on a post; object storage; limits per plan (Section 9)	A member attaches a screenshot; only that board's members can open it	**LATER** 1 to 2 weeks
M5	**Payment**	Stripe Checkout, customer portal, webhooks; plan limits enforced; pricing page	A real card pays, the board is upgraded, and cancelling downgrades it	**LATER** 1 to 2 weeks
M6	**Launch**	Uptime monitoring, error alerts, a tested database restore, support address, DMCA agent, announcement	You would be comfortable if a customer signed up while you slept	**LATER** about a week

Two changes to the plan, and why

- **The validation gate moved behind private boards.** Versions 1 and 2 put "five teams, two weeks" right after M2. Written down as a step somebody has to carry out, it does not work: there is one board, so five teams would read each other's posts, and so would anyone else. That was a mistake in the plan, mine. What can be done early is smaller and still useful: **a pilot with one team** on a board that is closed to everyone else.
- **M3 is split.** Email on accounts means a new column and migration, three new flows, and a mail provider. Push notifications mean keys, subscriptions and a second kind of message. Either is a release. Together they would break the rule that has kept six first runs clean: one step per release.
- **Closed mode is new**, and comes first because deployment made it urgent. One setting on Render, an invitation code: with it set, creating an account needs the code, and posts are shown only to members who are signed in. Without it, Brief! behaves as today. It also stands in for the bot check until 2.5: a bot cannot guess the code.

Release 2.4 in detail

Part	What it does	Notes
Email on accounts	A new account gives an email address. Existing accounts are asked for one after signing in.	Migration V3 adds the columns. V1 and V2 are not touched. One address, one account
Verification	A link is emailed; it is valid for 24 hours and works once. Until it is used, the member can read and cannot post.	Only a hash of the link's secret is stored, like a password
Password reset	"Forgot password?" sends a link valid for one hour, usable once. Setting the new password signs the account out everywhere.	The answer is the same whether or not the address exists, so the form cannot be used to find out who is a member
Sending	Through Resend's HTTPS interface. The key is a secret in Render's environment.	With no key set, as on your computer and in the tests, the message is written to the log instead. Nothing needs an account to be tested

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Part	What it does	Notes
Closed mode	With an invitation code set: registering needs the code; reading needs a sign-in.	Off by default. On for briefmessage.net
Deploy only what passed	render.yaml: deploy after the CI checks pass, not on every commit.	Today a commit that fails its tests would still be deployed
Fixes from the deployment	Every h2 folder ignored; the rate limiter's clean-up; one message for passwords that differ; a faster start-up if measurement shows where the time goes.	OTSR v6, Section 8
Your requests	The folder frontend becomes **frontend-spring**. The line "Also from OneTechly" for visitors who are not signed in.	The rename touches the CI workflow, the ignore files, the build script and the README; all are updated together

- **Not in 2.4:** the bot check, account deletion, Terms and Privacy pages, push notifications, longer sessions. They are 2.5.
- **How it will be checked:** as 2.3.0 was. All tests on the stand-in with real H2 and PostgreSQL; the migration from a copy of a 2.3 database; deliberate bugs; an independent review; the web app in a real browser. Sending real mail cannot be tried in the build environment; its first real test is your deployment.
- **What you do:** run the tests and send the line (the number will be higher than 207), push, watch CI and Render. Then set two values on Render: the Resend key and the invitation code. The release notes will say where.

4. M0 Done: Domain and Email

Step	State	When	Status
Email Routing activated	Three MX records, SPF and DKIM added and locked by Cloudflare	Oct 10	DONE
Destination address	onetechly@gmail.com, verified	Oct 10	DONE
Routing rules	hello@ and support@ to that inbox, both active. Catch-all disabled: mail to any other address is refused	Oct 10	DONE
Test	Sent to hello@ from another account at 22:35, received at 22:36	Oct 10	DONE
DNSSEC	Active	Oct 10	DONE
Test of support@	Not reported	-	YOU
Two-factor sign-in on the Cloudflare account	Not reported	-	YOU
Auto-renew for briefmessage.net	Not reported	-	YOU

- **Leave the catch-all rule disabled.** Switched on with "Drop" it would discard mistyped mail silently; switched on with forwarding it would deliver every spam address to your inbox.
- **The same for pixelperfectapi.net?** A good idea, with one check first. If that domain already has MX or SPF records in use, activating Email Routing can disturb them. Look at its DNS records page before clicking Activate, and send a screenshot if in doubt.

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- The 60-day rule from version 1 still holds: the domain cannot be moved to another registrar until early December. Nothing in this plan needs that.

5. M1 Done: 2.3.0 Verified

Check	Result	When
`.\mvnw.cmd package` on your machine	Tests run: 207, Failures: 0, Errors: 0, Skipped: 0. BUILD SUCCESS	Oct 9, 19:02
`.\mvnw.cmd test` on your machine	Tests run: 207, Failures: 0, Errors: 0, Skipped: 0. BUILD SUCCESS	Oct 10, 19:44
The same tests on PostgreSQL 16, real Spring	Passed, in GitHub Actions	Oct 10
The Docker image	Built and started in GitHub Actions; built again and deployed by Render	Oct 10 and 11
2.2.0, run once more	Tests run: 149. BUILD SUCCESS	Oct 10, 21:55

Details, suite by suite, are in OTSR v6, Section 3. The expected Flyway notice about H2 2.2.224 appeared, and nothing else did.

6. M2 Done: Hosting on Render

What	As built
Repository	github.com/Ambro19/brief, branch main, public. Dockerfile and render.yaml at the top level
Blueprint	"brief", linked to that repository. It created everything below
Web service	**brief**: Docker, Virginia, free plan. https://brief-v2vg.onrender.com
Database	**brief-db**: PostgreSQL 16, Virginia, free plan, created October 11
First deploy	October 11, 00:11 local time. About three and a half minutes from push to live, two of them the application's start-up
Proof the data is kept	The log line "Database: PostgreSQL"; three posts still present five hours and one redeploy later

Your questions of October 10 and 11, for the record

A second Render account for Brief!? No. One account, one workspace; Brief! is one more service beside PixelPerfect, with its own settings and database.

A separate frontend and backend, as PixelPerfect has? No. Brief! is one web service: the Spring Boot application serves the React web app itself. Creating it from the "backend" side was right, and there is no static site to add.

Why was PixelPerfect configured by hand and Brief! not? Not because of Python or Java. Brief! has a Blueprint file that holds the settings; it is one service, so nothing has to be told another service's address; and its only secret is generated by Render. PixelPerfect could have a render.yaml as well, but its Stripe and mail keys would still be typed in by hand, as every real secret is.

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Which plan, when

Stage	Web service	Database	Per month	Good for
Now	`free` 512 MB, a tenth of a processor	`free` 1 GB storage	$0	Looking at it yourself. The service sleeps after 15 minutes without traffic, and the application needs about two minutes to start. **The database expires on November 10**, is deleted 14 days later, and has no backups.
Pilot and launch	`0.5c-512mb` $7	`0.1c-256mb` $6	$13	Always on, half a processor, a database that stays and can be restored to any point in the last 3 days.
Growing	`1c-2g` $25	`0.5c-1g` $19	$44	More memory for the Java process, more connections

- **How to change plan:** edit the two `plan:` lines in render.yaml, commit and push. The Blueprint applies the change. A free database upgraded in time keeps its data.
- **When:** before the pilot team is invited, and in any case before November 10.
- **Shared allowances.** On a Hobby workspace, two custom domains are included and each further one costs $0.25 a month; 500 build minutes and 5 GB of bandwidth a month are included. PixelPerfect shares them. Look at Billing after the first week.
- **The Render address.** https://brief-v2vg.onrender.com still serves the site. Once you are used to briefmessage.net, switch "Render Subdomain" to Disabled under Settings > Custom Domains, so there is one address and one sign-in.

Plan names and prices from render.com/pricing and Render's Blueprint reference, October 9 to 11, 2026. A Java process on 512 MB is workable for a small board but has little headroom: watch memory in the first week of the pilot.

7. Connecting Cloudflare to Render, as Done

Step	As done on October 11	Status
Render: Settings > Custom Domains > Add Custom Domain	briefmessage.net added; Render added www.briefmessage.net and redirects it to the main name	DONE
Cloudflare: SSL/TLS mode	Full	DONE
Cloudflare: two CNAME records	@ and www, both to brief-v2vg.onrender.com	DONE
Proxy status	First created proxied, which is the form's default; switched to **DNS only** at 05:06	DONE
Render: Verify	Both names verified, both certificates issued	DONE
Open the site	https://briefmessage.net shows Brief! and its posts	DONE

- **Correction to version 2's guide.** It said "proxy status DNS only" and did not say that Cloudflare's Add record form has the proxy switched *on* by default. The step should read: switch the orange "Proxied" toggle off before saving.
- **A redirect rule in Cloudflare is not needed.** Render already sends www to the main name, and Cloudflare's rules act only on proxied records.

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- **"Always Use HTTPS" is not needed either,** for the same reason: with DNS-only records visitors reach Render directly, and Render redirects HTTP to HTTPS itself. Version 2 recommended switching it on; that applies only if the records are proxied one day.
- **An address with a dot at the end** (briefmessage.net.) answers "Not Found". It is a different name to Render. Nothing to fix.

Grey cloud or orange cloud, revisited

	DNS only (grey): now	Proxied (orange): possible later
What Cloudflare does	Answers DNS. Visitors connect straight to Render	Visitors connect to your Cloudflare zone, which forwards to Render's
You gain	One layer fewer; Render's certificate and redirect do the work	Cloudflare's cache, firewall rules, one free rate-limiting rule
Open question	None	Which visitor address the application then receives. Not confirmed; the DEBUG check would have to be repeated

8. Email

Need	Service	Cost	State
Receive mail at your own domain	Cloudflare Email Routing: hello@ and support@ forward to your inbox	Free	**DONE** Section 4
Send verification links and password resets	**Resend**, chosen October 11. Free plan as checked: 3,000 emails a month, 100 a day, one sending domain	$0 to start	**NEXT** with 2.4

What to prepare for 2.4

1. Create the account at resend.com yourself, in your name, with the onetechly address. I cannot create accounts.
2. Add the domain briefmessage.net there. Resend shows a few DNS records to add at Cloudflare.
3. **Send a screenshot of those records before adding them,** so they can be checked against the Email Routing records. A domain may have only one SPF record at each name; a second one at the same name breaks both.
4. Add them as DNS only. Resend then shows the domain as verified.
5. Create an API key. **Do not send it to anyone, and do not put it in the repository.** It goes into Render's environment; the 2.4 notes name the variable.

- **DMARC.** Cloudflare recommends a DMARC record. Add it together with Resend's records, starting with the policy "none", which only reports. Tighten it once real mail is flowing.
- **SMTP is not unsafe,** and is not Google's. It is the standard by which mail servers pass mail on, Gmail included. Brief! uses Resend's HTTPS interface for a narrower reason: Render's free instances block the SMTP ports. PixelPerfect sending by SMTP is fine.
- **Gmail is for receiving here, not for sending as the product.** Mail from Brief! should come from an address at briefmessage.net, signed for that domain, or it lands in spam.

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9. New Features: Attachments and the Installable App

Attachments: your proposal, assessed

> **Verdict**
>
> **Yes. Attachments belong in Brief!.** "The report is attached" is exactly the kind of post a 255-character board is for, and a screenshot often says what a short text cannot. Build them after private boards (M4), starting with images, PDF and text files. Treat video separately.

Your screenshot of the phone's message app shows what opens behind the + button. Not all of it suits a team board:

In the phone's menu	For Brief!	Why
Gallery, Camera	**YES** first	A screenshot or a photo of a whiteboard is the most common thing a team adds to a short update. On a phone, the same button offers the camera.
Files (PDF, text, documents)	**YES** first	"Minutes of today's meeting attached."
Video	**LATER** and small	Large to store and to send, and a video must be converted before it plays on every device. Start by letting a post link to where the video already is; allow short clips once storage costs are known.
GIFs, Stickers	No	Chat features. They work against "every post gets read".
Location, Contacts	No	Not what a team board is for.
Schedule send	Worth considering	"Post this on Monday at 9" suits planned team updates. It is not an attachment: it needs a timer on the server and no storage. A candidate for after M4.

Why after private boards, and not now

- **Who can open the file.** Today everyone who registers sees every post. A file on such a board is public. On a private board it is a team's own business, and the rule "only members of this board may download it" has something to check against.
- **Legal exposure.** Hosting strangers' files is where copyright complaints and worse begin (Section 13). A private, invited group changes that picture.
- **Where the file lives.** Inside a container, a file is erased at every deploy. Attachments need storage outside the application, which only makes sense once the application is hosted (M2).
- **Building it once.** Every file will belong to a workspace. Written before workspaces exist, the feature would have to be rewritten in M4.

How it would be built

Piece	Choice	Why
Where files live	Object storage: Cloudflare R2	It speaks the same protocol as Amazon S3, so standard Java libraries work. First 10 GB stored are free each month, then $0.015 per GB per month, and downloads are not charged.

Piece	Choice	Why
Upload	The browser asks the server for a one-time upload address and sends the file straight to storage	Large files never pass through the 512 MB Java process
Database	A new table: one row per file, with its post, its board, name, type, size and storage key. A new migration, V3 or later	The post itself stays 255 characters; the file is beside it
Download	The server checks board membership, then hands out an address that works for a few minutes	Private files stay private. No public bucket
Limits	10 MB per file; up to 4 files per post; images, PDF and plain text; the type is checked from the content, not the name	Predictable cost; a renamed program is refused
On screen	Images as a thumbnail that opens larger; other files as a named chip with their size; a + button beside Post, as in your screenshot	The post text stays the main thing
Safety	User files that a browser could run (HTML, SVG) are offered as downloads, never displayed inside the site	A file must not be able to act as a page of briefmessage.net

R2 prices from developers.cloudflare.com/r2/pricing, October 9, 2026. Effort: one to two weeks after M4. Pricing effects: Section 11.

The installable app: what 2.3.0 has

Capability	State	Notes
Install from the browser	DONE	Android and desktop Chrome or Edge: the line "Install Brief! on this device". iPhone and iPad: Share, then Add to Home Screen; the app says so.
Own window and icon	DONE	No address bar. The icon is the green square with the white bar.
Opens without a connection	DONE	The app's own files are kept on the device; the screen says "You're offline". Posts are never stored on the device.
Unread count on the icon	DONE	Where the system supports it, and while the app is running.
Stay signed in	DONE	Ticked by default in the installed app. Lasts until sign-out or 12 hours, whichever comes first. Longer with M3b.
Notification while the app is closed	LATER	M3b. See below.

- **It needs HTTPS**, which https://briefmessage.net now has. The install line shows on the live site in Edge. Installing on a phone has not been tried yet.
- **No app store**, no store fee, no review. An update reaches every installed copy at the next deploy.
- **It is not a native app.** It will not appear in the App Store or Google Play. For a team tool that people are invited to by a link, that is rarely a loss.

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Next for the app: notifications that reach a closed app (M3b)

This is your original idea for mentions: the member notices even while away, working or in a meeting. The browser standard for it is Web Push. The server sends a small message through the phone maker's push service, and the service worker that 2.3.0 installed shows it. It works on Android and on desktop browsers. On iPhone and iPad it works from iOS 16.4, only for a site that was added to the Home Screen, and only after the member allows it with a tap inside that installed app. The manifest shipped in 2.3.0 already meets those conditions. It belongs with M3b because a notification is tied to an account on a device, and accounts have to be real first (M3a).

10. Stripe

> **Your question: implement Stripe in this cycle, or wait?**
>
> **Wait.** Not because it is hard; PixelPerfect already taught you the three parts. Because there is nothing to charge for yet.
>
> What Brief! sells is a board. Until M4 there is one public board, so a subscription has nothing to attach to. Stripe also expects the public site to show a price, a refund and cancellation policy, a privacy policy and a support contact before live payments, and those pages are planned for M3b. And the validation gate (Section 3) sits before M5 on purpose: if two of five teams would pay, build it; if none would, you have saved those weeks.
>
> What costs nothing and can be done any time: create a separate Stripe account for Brief! under your existing login, in sandbox mode, so its name and reports stay apart from PixelPerfect's.

The design from version 1 is unchanged, and is repeated here so this document stands on its own. Three parts: **Checkout** (Stripe's hosted payment page), the **customer portal** (Stripe's hosted "manage my subscription" page) and **webhooks** (Stripe telling your server what happened). Card numbers never touch your server.

Step	What happens	Your code
1	The board's owner clicks Upgrade	The server creates a Checkout Session in subscription mode for that workspace and returns its URL
2	Stripe's page takes the card	None
3	Stripe calls your webhook: `checkout.session.completed`	Store the Stripe customer id and subscription id on the workspace
4	Stripe calls: `invoice.paid`	Mark the workspace as on the paid plan until the end of the period. **This event, not the browser's return, unlocks the plan.**
5	Each month: `invoice.paid` again, or `invoice.payment_failed`	Extend, or warn the owner
6	The owner opens "Manage billing"	The server creates a customer portal session and redirects there
7	Stripe calls: `customer.subscription.updated` or `.deleted`	When the status becomes canceled or unpaid, return the workspace to the free plan

- **Verify every webhook call** against the endpoint's signing secret, using the raw request body (`Webhook.constructEvent` in com.stripe:stripe-java). An unverified webhook lets anyone grant themselves the paid plan.
- **Expect duplicates and wrong order.** Keep a table of processed event ids; act on the state inside the event.

- **Answer 200 quickly**, then do the work. The route needs no login; the signature is its authentication.
- **Secrets live in Render's environment**, never in the repository. Test and live keys differ, and so do their webhook secrets.

Fees for a United States account as checked on October 6, 2026: 2.9% + 30 cents per successful domestic card charge; Stripe Billing adds 0.7% of subscription volume on the pay-as-you-go plan; Stripe Tax, if used, 0.5% per transaction where you are registered. The customer portal is included.

11. Pricing Model

A price is a guess until someone pays it. You asked whether attachments should change the plans. My view: they should change what is *in* the plans, not the price.

Proposed starting model: flat price per board, now with files

Plan	Price	Includes	Files (from M4a)	Purpose
Free	$0	One board, up to 5 members, the last 90 days of posts	Images only, 100 MB for the board	Lets a team start in a minute and feel the habit. The member limit, not a time limit, prompts the upgrade.
Team	**$12 a month per board**, or $120 a year	Up to 25 members, full history, mention alerts by email and push, export of posts	Images, PDF and text; 10 MB per file; 5 GB for the board	The plan most paying customers would be on
Larger	Later, on request	More members, single sign-on, audit log	More storage, video	Build only when someone asks

Why keep $12 when files are added	Why give files a limit at all
Storage is cheap. A Team board that fills its 5 GB costs about 8 cents a month at R2's list price ($0.015 a GB), and the first 10 GB across all boards are free.	The limit protects against misuse more than against cost: without one, a board becomes somebody's backup drive.
Nobody has paid $12 yet. Changing the number now replaces one guess with another. The validation gate is where it gets tested.	It also makes the difference between Free and Team something a team can feel: more people, all the history, real files.

What comparable tools charge

Product	Paid plan	List price	Unit	A team of 10 pays, per month
Slack	Pro	$8.75 monthly, $7.25 billed annually	per user	$87.50
Zulip Cloud	Standard	$8 monthly, $6.67 billed annually	per user	$80
Range	Pro	$8	per user	$80
Twist	Unlimited	$6	per user	$60
Microsoft Teams Essentials	-	$4, billed annually	per user	$40

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Product	Paid plan	List price	Unit	A team of 10 pays, per month
Geekbot (stand-up bot)	Basic	$3 monthly, $2.50 billed annually	per participant	$30
Basecamp	Freelancer	$25	flat	$25

Public list prices as checked on the vendors' own pages on October 6, 2026 (not rechecked for this version). These tools do far more than Brief!. They are shown to locate the ceiling, not to claim equivalence.

What one paying board is worth

Per paying board, per month	Amount
Price	$12.00
Card fee: 2.9% + $0.30	- $0.65
Stripe Billing: 0.7%	- $0.08
Left before tax, hosting and storage	**$11.27**
Fixed hosting at launch (Section 12)	$13 a month, whatever the number of boards
Paying boards needed to cover hosting	**2**

Read with care

These figures are arithmetic on list prices, not a forecast of income. They leave out sales tax (Section 13), refunds, disputes and your time. A free plan also has a cost: every free board uses the same server.

12. Monthly Cost at Each Stage

Item	Now	Pilot and launch	Growing
Domain (briefmessage.net)	Paid for the year; see your Cloudflare invoice	same	same
Cloudflare DNS, DNSSEC, email routing	$0	$0	$0
Render web service	$0 (sleeps when idle)	$7	$25
Render Postgres	$0 (expires November 10)	$6	$19
Extra custom domains on Render	up to $0.50 if the workspace's two included domains are in use	same	same
Sending email: Resend (from 2.4)	-	$0 within the free allowance	a paid plan when the allowance is passed
File storage on R2 (from M4a)	-	-	$0 within the first 10 GB, then $0.015 per GB

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Item	Now	Pilot and launch	Growing
Stripe (from M5)	-	-	A share of each payment only
Fixed total per month	**$0**, or $0.50	**$13**, or $13.50	**about $45**, plus email

One-time: registering a DMCA agent with the United States Copyright Office costs $6 and is renewed every three years. Section 13 explains what that is. So far the project has cost the domain's registration and nothing else.

13. Legal and Compliance Checklist

A checklist of what a United States product with accounts and user-written content normally has at launch, with where to read more. **I am not a lawyer or a tax adviser.** Use this to prepare the conversation with one, not to replace it.

> **On timing: the policy pages can wait a little, as you suggested**
>
> Agreed. Terms, Privacy and the refund and cancellation policy describe what the product does with people's data and money, so they are easier to write once that is settled. They are needed at two points: Terms and Privacy before strangers can register (M3b), and the refund and cancellation policy before a live payment (M5). Until then the people using Brief! are you and teams you invited.

Item	What it is	Needed by	Where to start
Terms of Service	The contract with users: acceptable use, what happens to content, how accounts end. State a minimum age of 13.	M3b	A lawyer, or a reputable template adapted to what Brief! really does
Privacy Policy	What you collect (username, email, posts, later files, IP address in logs), why, who processes it (Render, Cloudflare, Stripe, the email provider), and how to delete it	M3b	Required by Stripe before live payments
Refund and cancellation policy	When a customer can cancel and whether anything is refunded	M5	Stripe's "website checklist" page, on docs.stripe.com
Children (COPPA)	The law covers services directed at children under 13, or that knowingly collect their data. A work tool that states 13+ is the usual approach.	M3b	ftc.gov, COPPA frequently asked questions
Copyright complaints (DMCA)	A named contact for copyright complaints, registered with the Copyright Office. Explained below.	M6, and before attachments are open to strangers	copyright.gov/dmca-directory
Files from users (new)	With attachments, the host has to be able to remove a file quickly and to say how to report one. Some kinds of illegal material carry duties of their own.	Before M4a	Ask the lawyer who reviews the Terms what a host must do when illegal material is reported
New York sales tax	New York treats software accessed over the internet as taxable when sold to customers in New York.	M5	tax.ny.gov, bulletin TB-ST-128. Stripe Tax can calculate it. Confirm with an accountant.

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Item	What it is	Needed by	Where to start
Other states and countries	Rules differ and have thresholds. Most do not apply to a product with a handful of customers.	After M5	An accountant; Stripe Tax's monitoring
Email (CAN-SPAM)	Marketing email needs a postal address and a working unsubscribe. Password resets and receipts are treated differently.	M3b	ftc.gov, CAN-SPAM compliance guide
European users (GDPR)	Applies if you offer the service to people in the EU, not merely because the site can be opened there.	Before marketing there	Decide whether to market there before worrying
The business	OneTechly, LLC already exists and can own Brief!, as it owns PixelPerfect.	-	Your accountant, for how to keep the products' books apart
The name	"Brief" is a common word in software.	Before paying for a logo or advertising	Search the USPTO trademark database

What the DMCA line means

You asked what "registering a DMCA agent costs $6 and is renewed every three years" really means. In plain terms:

- **The problem.** On Brief! people post text, and later files. If one of them posts something that belongs to somebody else, for example a paid report or a photo, the owner could hold the site responsible.
- **The protection.** A United States law, the Digital Millennium Copyright Act, says a site that only stores what its users post is not liable for their copyright infringement, provided it follows a procedure. That protection is called the "safe harbor" (section 512 of the Copyright Act). It is not automatic.
- **The procedure has four parts:** name a contact who receives copyright complaints, the "designated agent", and register that contact in the Copyright Office's online directory; publish the same contact on the site; remove the material promptly when a proper complaint arrives; and have, and apply, a rule that closes the accounts of people who do it repeatedly.
- **The $6.** The Copyright Office charges $6 for each designation, amendment or resubmission. A designation expires three years after it is registered unless it is renewed, and renewing means submitting it again for $6. The agent can be a person, a job title, a department or an outside firm; one per service provider. Here the service provider would be OneTechly, LLC, and the contact could be support@briefmessage.net, which now exists.
- **When.** It costs little and takes minutes, so before public launch (M6) at the latest. It matters more once attachments exist.

Fee and renewal period from the Copyright Office's own questions-and-answers page, copyright.gov/dmca-directory/faq.html, read on October 9, 2026. Whether and how the safe harbor applies to your service is a question for a lawyer.

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14. Scaling: What Breaks Next, and the Fix

The first five rows were done in 2.3.0 and are now running in production. The next four were found by deploying it. The rest is unchanged, in the order it will be needed:

Today	Becomes a problem when	Step	State
H2 file database; schema changed by Hibernate at start-up	The first deployment	PostgreSQL; Flyway migrations; foreign keys	**DONE** 2.3.0
Usernames differing only in capitals	Two members with "the same" name	A unique lower-case key	**DONE** 2.3.0
Mentions endpoint returns everything	A member mentioned thousands of times	Paged like the feed	**DONE** 2.3.0
Static files marked "do not cache"	Visitors far from the server, or many of them	/assets cached for a year. Later: proxy through Cloudflare	**DONE** 2.3.0
The login limit counted the proxy, not the visitor	The first deployment	Read the proxy's header; count IPv6 by block	**DONE** 2.3.0
Start-up takes about two minutes on a tenth of a processor (new)	Every wake-up from sleep and every deploy	A paid instance; then measure and trim the start-up	Pilot; 2.4
Every commit is deployed, tested or not (new)	The first commit that fails its tests	Deploy only after the CI checks pass	2.4
The rate limiter's clean-up scans every key on each attempt (new)	A flood of login attempts under new names	Clean up at most once per interval	2.4
No backups (new)	The first mistake in production data	The paid database: restore to any point in the last 3 days	Pilot
Mention look-up compares the post with every username	Tens of thousands of members	Count only names written with @, looked up by index	**LATER**
Every browser asks every 15 seconds	Hundreds of people online at once	Server-Sent Events: the server pushes new posts down one open connection	After M4
Rate-limit counts and signed-out tokens in one server's memory	A second server instance, or the wish to keep them across restarts	Render Key Value (Redis-compatible), or shorter-lived tokens	When a second instance is needed
One instance	Memory or processor is the limit, or zero-downtime deploys matter	A larger instance first. Then two instances, which the step above makes possible	When measured
One public board	The first team that wants privacy	A workspace id on every row and in every query	M4
Files have nowhere to live	The first attachment	Object storage outside the application (R2)	M4a
Alerts need the app to be open	A member who is away from the screen	Web Push through the service worker 2.3.0 installed	M3b

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Today	Becomes a problem when	Step	State
Console logs only	The first problem you cannot reproduce	Structured logs, an uptime check, error alerts. 2.3.0 adds one start-up line naming the database	M6

The order matters more than the list. Each step is taken when a measurement or a customer asks for it, not before. Brief! on one small instance with PostgreSQL will serve its first hundred teams.

15. This Week

#	From version 2	State
1	Run the 2.3.0 tests and send the line	**DONE** 207 of 207
2	M0: Email Routing, DNSSEC, two-factor sign-in, auto-renew	**DONE** except the two confirmations
3	Push 2.3.0 to GitHub and watch the five CI jobs	**DONE** all green
4	M2: Render Blueprint, then the domain	**DONE** live on October 11
5	Two answers for the next release	**DONE** Resend; no study copy

Now, in this order:

1. **Four confirmations, ten minutes** (OTSR v6, Section 12): two-factor sign-in and auto-renew at Cloudflare; the one-time DEBUG check of the visitor's address; a screenshot of brief-db's Networking page; a test message to support@.
2. **Decide whether the repository stays public.** Public is a good portfolio piece. It also shows the docs folder, with this roadmap and the pricing ideas, to anyone.
3. **Resend:** create the account, add the domain, and send the screenshot of its DNS records before adding them (Section 8).
4. **Tell me if you disagree** with the two changes of Section 3: the split of M3, and the closed mode. Without an objection, 2.4 is built as described there.
5. **Then 2.4 arrives** as a complete zip, as always: run the tests, send the line, push, and set the two new values on Render.
6. **Before inviting a pilot team:** move both plans to the paid ones ($13 a month), and by November 10 in any case.

> **Bottom line**
>
> Three milestones closed in two days, with no failed first run. The site is real, and that changes what matters: until October 11 the risk was that it would not work; from now on the risk is who can use it and what they can do. So the next release is about the door: accounts that can be recovered, and a board that only invited people can enter.
>
> Money needed so far: none. Money needed for the pilot: $13 a month. The expensive part is still your time.

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Sources checked for this version

- Render: render.com/docs/yaml-spec (plan names, inbound rules, deploy triggers); render.com/docs/infrastructure-as-code; render.com/docs/free; render.com/docs/custom-domains; render.com/docs/configure-cloudflare-dns; render.com/docs/tls. October 10 and 11, 2026.
- Cloudflare: developers.cloudflare.com, "How Orange-to-Orange works"; the Email Sending beta announcement of April 16, 2026. October 10 and 11, 2026.
- Resend's free allowance: a third-party summary dated May to July 2026, not Resend's own pricing page. Confirm it there when you create the account.
- Everything recorded as done comes from the author's own screenshots, terminal output and Render log of October 9 to 11, 2026.
- Stripe fees and competitors' prices: as checked for version 1 on October 6, 2026. R2 prices and the Copyright Office's fee: as checked for version 2 on October 9.

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